



know and appreciate their position. And I just happen to be in this seat today. The equation is of a different flavour. So, I just don't feel it [the gender issue].

Q: Sebi has been taking steps to empower women at the workplace, making it mandatory for the Top 1,000 companies to have at least one woman independent director. Are you looking at increasing the number of companies now that you know a beginning has been made?

A: The gender issue is very important to our country and to me. However, do I think that a dozen or two dozen privileged women like myself, being on a dozen boards each is going to cut it for our country? Absolutely not. And so that thinking has manifested in one of the key metrics that Sebi has articulated as core ESG or core BRSR (Business Responsibility and Sustainability Report) as we call it. On the gender issue, we have received representation that, you know, include this parameter or that parameter. We said look, finally, what is important? So, we have identified only two metrics. One is, what percentage of your payroll cost goes to women. It is simple. Don't do this tokenism of putting two more women on the board and say we are brilliant. Let's see the disclosure and say, what percentage of your manpower cost goes to women. It will take care of everything. It will take care of whether you have equal number of women at junior, senior, or middle positions. Do you pay them equally to have them in key positions? Do you encourage women to come back to work after their child-bearing period is over? It takes care of everything. So that is the bottom line for us.

And the second metric is the POSH complaints because obviously that's still a thing. And you know, we see that quite frequently. For us, that is more important.

If there is a company that has set up a factory in a Tier IV town and has built a fabulous hostel for its women employees, and has invited the parents of all those employees to say we are keeping your daughter safe here, and this is a safe environment in which they can work and that factory has 80 per cent women—that's far more important than having another person like me on the board. So, we would like to see that gender manifest down the line. We would like to see more and more women KMPs [key management personnel]. And then when you have all of that, it will bubble up automatically to the board but simply, you know, parachuting in someone at the top and doing nothing at the bottom, I don't think it's going to cut it for our country.

Q: You have been in the market for long, even outside Sebi. How do you see the standards of governance evolve over the years? What do you see as the improvements or the areas of concern?

A: Governance goes to trust. And I think that is the fundamental approach that Sebi takes to fostering that trust is disclosure. Our view is that Sebi should not be interfering in what a company does or does not do. It only asks two things on behalf of the investor because the investors are diffused and they do not have bargaining power and so the regulator is representing the investors. We ask for only two things. The first is disclosure, which is to say that in the following things,

41